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NEWSPAPER

12th April, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

15th WEEK



INVASION OF IRAQ ... 15 YEARS

**UPSC CSE –
GS II**

**GS II Effect of Policies and Politics of Developed and
Developing Countries on India's interests.**



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... DISCUSSION

12th APRIL, 2018

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Fifteen years after

The architects of the Iraq war
are yet to be held to account

Fifteen years ago, on April 9, a few weeks into the U.S.-led invasion of Iraq, a 39-foot statue of Saddam Hussein in Baghdad's al-Fardous Square was brought down under the watch of American troops. It was an iconic moment that highlighted more than just the end of the Ba'ath party's decades-long reign. Within a month, U.S. President George W. Bush had declared "mission accomplished" in Iraq. But one and a half decades later, the country is still fighting the ghosts of the destructive war. The war, which began on March 20, 2003, had no legitimate basis, being founded on misleading intelligence information, if not downright lies. The U.S. did not have a UN mandate to use force against Iraq. Repeated attempts by the Bush administration to get Security Council approval failed. But the U.S. went ahead with forming an international coalition that included the U.K., and attacking Iraq, citing mainly two reasons – that the Saddam administration possessed weapons of mass destruction and that it had ties with al-Qaeda. Both claims turned out to be false. The occupying troops failed to find any weapon of mass destruction in Iraq, while al-Qaeda in Iraq was actually founded after the invasion. The post-war management of Iraq was disastrous. The U.S. first disbanded the Iraqi military, leaving tens of thousands of soldiers jobless overnight, which posed a security threat. There was no coherent strategy to stabilise post-Saddam Iraq or to address the sectarian power struggle to fill the vacuum.

It is difficult to see what the U.S. and its allies achieved from a war that killed hundreds of thousands of Iraqis and displaced millions. More importantly, by destroying the state apparatus in Iraq, Washington threw a multi-ethnic, multi-religious country into utter chaos. It was in this chaos that Abu Musab al-Zarqawi found the fertile ground to build his terrorist empire which, after his death and under the leadership of Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi, transformed itself into the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria. In effect, the war got rid of a ruthless dictator, but left the country in a worse and much more dangerous situation – in fact, in disarray and perpetual violence. Iraq now has a functional government, but with deepening sectarian and ethnic fault lines. Despite the humanitarian and political tragedy that is still unfolding, none of the architects of the war has been taken to task. No action has been taken even based on the U.K.'s Chilcot report, which took apart the arguments used to justify the war. The Iraq war will remain a reminder of not only one of the greatest humanitarian catastrophes of the century but also of a grave failure of the international system.

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3 Fifteen years after: on Iraq war

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US INVASION OF IRAQ

- US led invasion of Iraq completed 15 years on 20 March, 2003.
- US along with International Coalition, including UK, attacked Iraq.



SADDAM HUSSEIN

WHAT WERE THE MAIN REASONS?

- 1 Saddam Hussein administration possessed weapons of mass destruction.
- 2 The Saddam Hussein administration had ties with Al-Qaeda.

Both the claims turned out to be false, and no weapons of mass destruction could be found and Al-Qaeda was formed in Iraq actually after the invasion.



WHAT ABOUT THE POST WAR MANAGEMENT OF IRAQ?

- 1 US disbanded Iraqi military leaving tens of thousands of soldiers jobless overnight.
- 2 There was no coherent strategy for stabilising post Saddam Iraq.

It killed hundreds of thousands of Iraqis and displaced millions. It destroyed the state apparatus. It threw a multi-ethnic, multi-religious country into chaos.



Abu Musab al-Zarqawi



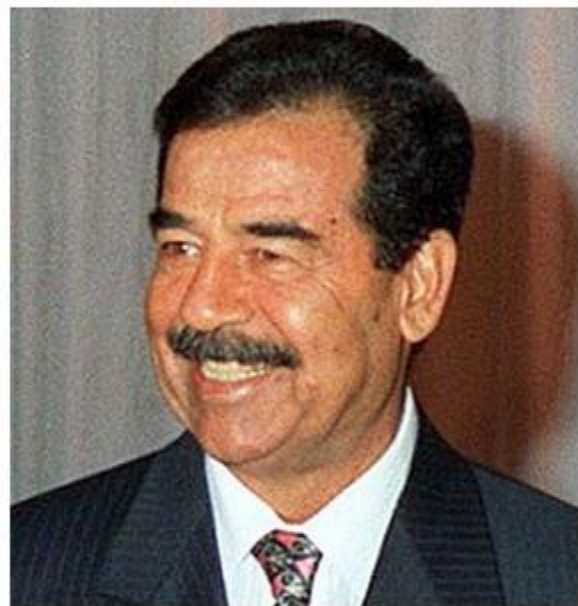
Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi

HOW THE ISLAMIC STATE OF IRAQ AND SYRIA WAS BORN?

- 1 Amidst the chaos, Abu Musab al-Zarqawi found the fertile ground to build his terrorist empire.
- 2 After his death and under the leadership of Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi, it transformed itself into the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria.







SADDAM HUSSEIN

WHAT CAN WE CONCLUDE IN A NUT SHELL?

- 1** The war got rid of a ruthless dictator, Saddam Hussein.
- 2** It left the country in a worse and much more dangerous situation.
- 3** The country is in perpetual violence. The country now got a functional Government, but with deepening sectarian and ethnic fault lines.
- 4** None of the architects of the war has been taken to task.
- 5** No action has been taken even based on the U.K.'s Chilcot report, which took apart the arguments used to justify the war.



Iraq war will remain a reminder of not only one of the greatest humanitarian catastrophes of the century, but also of a grave failure of the international system.

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For Suggestions:

suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

OUR TEAM

G. V. Rao
K. Srikanth
D. Sunil Kumar
L. V. Krishna
D. Chaitanya

Amrita Naidu
M. Binukrishna
G. Ravi Babu
D. Joji
K. Victor Babu

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